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Professional Development Policy

Effective January 1, 2022

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1. Purpose

The Professional Development Policy refers to the company's learning and development programs and activities to support Partners of the Americas' (POA) global workforce.

In the modern competitive environment, professionals need to replenish their knowledge and acquire new skills to do their jobs better. The purpose of this policy is to provide guidelines to apply to POA's Professional Development Global Funds, as well as finding new ways towards professional success.

2. Policy Elements

Under this policy, POA understands that staff, Senior Leadership and Human Resources (HR) should collaborate to build a continuous learning and development culture. The Professional Development Program is learning undertaken by staff and their supervisors to maintain and advance skills, knowledge, and competencies, specifically as it relates and adds value to the job, and POA's mission.

It is a dynamic process and can be achieved not only through participation in formal coursework, but also through professional experience, collaboration, mentoring, participation in activities of professional organizations, and independent study and research. In addition, POA has procured a cloud-based learning management system that contains and serves as a central learning hub with thousands of educational micro-courses and other resources.

While the engagement in professional development varies widely between groups and individuals, the following areas of knowledge and skills development should be considered relevant to the success of the staff and POA's mission and initiatives:

- Business skills, including financial stewardship, foreign language acquisition, technical knowledge related to POA's technical areas, human resource management, and strategic leadership.
- Communication skills, including basic skills, conflict management, resolution, negotiation, and facilitation.
- Team communications and/or team-building skills.
- Research funding and grant administration knowledge and skills.
- Knowledge and skills related to diversity, equity, and inclusion.
- Knowledge and skills in the use of technology to increase the efficiency and effectiveness of POA's business processes/practices.
- Maintaining and developing professional expertise.
- Other core skills, including, but not limited to, critical thinking, problem-solving, public speaking, professional writing, and intercultural fluency

3. Program Eligibility

All professional development opportunities under this policy must be related to improving the skills of individual staff members in their present jobs, and/or to enhancing staff potential for advancement to a position within POA which the individual has a reasonable and clear expectation of achieving. Professional development opportunities should first focus on helping staff excel in their current position. If staff has mastered all skills required for their current role, the funds in this program can be used to develop skills for a future growth opportunity within POA.

4. Staff Eligibility

This policy applies to all POA full-time employees, and full-time consultants (case by case), that have completed more than 90 days of employment (completion of employment probatory period in good standing is required). This policy applies to all staff who work exclusively for POA. Exceptions to this policy must be approved by the President & CEO and HR.

5. General Guidelines

- All eligible staff are covered by this policy without discriminating against race, disability, gender, age, religion, appearance, citizenship or immigration status, sexual orientation, genetic information, marital status, social or economic status, or any protected group or affiliation under State, Federal Law or local country regulations.
- Supervisors and unit VPs will evaluate the success of professional development efforts and must keep records for reference and better improvement opportunities.
- All professional development efforts should respect cost time limitations, as well as individual and business needs.
- All professional development requests should be cross-checked first to see if the relevant course material is available on POA's cloud-based learning management system before submitting a request for external opportunities.
- Supervisors and unit VPs are encouraged to use their allocated professional development budgets and time to support the program and team's needs.
- Staff should try to make the most out of their professional development opportunities by studying and finding ways to apply knowledge to their work.

6. Approval of Professional Development

Approval of professional development opportunities must be provided by the staff member's supervisor and the following Approval Team:

- Unit VP and HR Director for Home Office Staff
- Country Director or Project Director / Chief of Party, designated field HR representative for field staff[1]

The Approval Team must ensure that the request complies with this policy and ensure that the professional development is documented in the staff's personnel file.

[1] If the field program does not have a designated HR representative, the Home Office HR team will designate the individual to be on the Approval Team

7. Cost

Under this policy, eligible staff may request reimbursement from the Professional Development funds as follows:

- Up to US$ 750 per calendar year[2]

Eligible costs may include, but not limited to:

- Onsite workshop cost with a third-party vendor.
- Purchase of textbooks, E-books, and training materials, printed or download.
- Tuition, registration, and admission fees.
- Costs of logistic, transportation, lodging, airfare, and meals associated with any Professional Development program.

POA will pay for the eligible costs up front upon request.

8. Unallowable costs

- Late payment fees.
- Costs funded by outside sources, including costs covered by scholarships, student loans, or other outside aid.
- Course material offered by POA's learning management system.
- Fees associated with college or university entrance exams (GMAT, GRE' LSATS, TOEFL, etc).

9. Hours and Attendance

POA encourages staff to develop a continuous learning culture; however, course attendance and completion of studies for Professional Development must not interfere with the employee's core hours of work, unless approved by the Approval Team. POA may approve employees to use their PTO as needed. An additional Flex Work Arrangement (FWA) request may be available to address Professional Development scheduling needs. In addition, staff must ensure satisfactory job performance during enrollment in any Professional Development program.

10.Application Process

The staff member will need to determine with the help of their supervisor which type of program will work best to improve or master performance and project needs in their current role.

The following must be considered when determining a Professional Development program:

- **The nature and purpose of the course of study/opportunity**: Is the opportunity related to the current job or a target position within POA?
- **Potential benefits**: Will the outcome of the course/opportunity be beneficial to the staff and POA?
- **Staff eligibility**: Is the staff eligible for participation in the program as stipulated in this policy; and

[2] Pro-rated for eligible staff who begin working with Partners in the calendar year

- **The staff's current performance:** If the staff needs to improve performance, the courses/opportunities should first focus on capacity building for the current position prior to developing skills for potential future positions within POA.

Once a Professional Development program has been identified by the staff and approved by their supervisor, the staff must complete the Professional Development Application Form. Once completed, the Professional Development Application Form will be submitted to the Approval Team, as defined in Section 6, for review and approval, BEFORE registering and commencing the course/opportunty. Once the Professional Development Application is approved, the staff will be notified to start making the arrangements to complete and attend the Professional Development program requested.

11.Payment & Reimbursement Request

The Professional Development program courses can be paid using POA's credit card, or via ACH/Wire. In some cases, POA does not pay for the Professional Development program directly; therefore, staff will have to pay upfront and provide the following supporting documents and attach them to the expense report for reimbursement. The HR & F&A team will provide guidelines on a case-by-case basis.

- Expense report (must follow ACH or Wire requirement under F&A guidelines)
- Professional Development Request Form approved by the Approval Team
- Proof of payment (receipt)
- If Applicable, proof of passing grades and/ or certification of attendance